

Mav and the Ice Cream Justice

Maverick was trying to finish his math homework when the room temperature plummeted and the smell of cedar-scented justice filled the air.

Professor Balthazar Bucktooth appeared, but he wasn't his usual ghostly self. He was wearing a dark blue bandana over his eyes (which kept slipping down his snout) and a cape made from a discarded "Quick-Dry" car wash towel.

"Maverick! Put down the pencil! The foundation of society is cracking, and we are the only ones with the structural adhesive to fix it!" the Professor declared, striking a heroic pose on Mav's lamp.

"Professor, are you wearing a bandana? I can see your whiskers poking through the top," Mav said.

"Nonsense! I am no longer the Professor! I am **The Timber Titan!** And you shall be my sidekick, **The Splinter!** Together, we shall roam the streets of Clovis and enforce Beaver Justice!"

Against his better judgment, Mav followed the glowing blue beaver out the window. They patrolled the local park, ducking behind trash cans and bushes.

"Look there!" Bucktooth hissed, pointing a ghostly paw at an elderly man sitting on a park bench. The man was slowly eating a sandwich. "He's loitering with **excessive ham density!** The structural weight of that sourdough is a threat to the bench's integrity! CITIZEN, DROP THE PROTEIN!"

The Professor dived from a tree, attempting to tackle the man's sandwich. Instead, he passed right through the sourdough, through the man's lap, and landed head-first in a puddle.

"Professor, stop!" Mav whispered, pulling the beaver out of the mud. "That's not a crime! He's just having lunch!"

"He was a threat to the infrastructure, Splinter! I saw the bread sag!"

They moved on to a mailbox. Bucktooth stared at it with narrowed eyes. "Suspicious. Look at its stance. It's too hollow. I bet it's full of **substandard blueprints** and letters written in crayon! I must dismantle it for public safety!"

Bucktooth began gnawing on the corner of the metal mailbox. Since he was a ghost, it just sounded like a faint, high-pitched scratching, like a confused mouse.

"Professor, leave the mail alone!" Mav cried. "That's a federal offense! You're making everything worse! Last week you tried to arrest a sprinkler for 'unauthorized hydration,' and the week before you tackled a cat for 'excessive purr-vibrations!'"

"Beaver Justice is swift and uncompromising, Maverick!"

"Beaver Justice is just you being annoying!" Mav snapped. "Look, the real police are right over there. Let them do their jobs. They're looking for real criminals, not people with heavy sandwiches!"

Mav marched toward the local ice cream parlor, *The Frozen Scoop*, to calm his nerves. He bought a triple-scoop **Cinnamon-Cheddar-Crunch** cone (a flavor only a kid with Mav's history could appreciate). Bucktooth, sulking, managed to manifest enough physical energy to grab his own ghostly cone of "Frozen Wood-Pulp Delight."

"I suppose you're right," Bucktooth sighed, his cape dragging in the dirt. "My version of justice is perhaps too... foundational for this primitive world."

Suddenly, a man wearing a ski mask sprinted out of the jewelry store next door, clutching a bag of diamonds and a very expensive-looking gold watch.

"STOP HIM!" the shopkeeper yelled.

Mav froze. "Professor! A real criminal! Do something!"

"I... I can't!" Bucktooth whimpered, looking at his ice cream. "I'm in the middle of a delicate dairy experience! The structural integrity of this scoop is failing!"

As the robber sprinted toward them, the Professor's ghostly ice cream began to tilt. In a moment of panic, Bucktooth tried to lick the side of the cone, but his tongue slipped. The entire triple-scoop of frozen wood-pulp slid off the cone and landed right in the middle of the sidewalk.

The robber, eyes fixed on his getaway car, didn't see the glowing, supernatural puddle of slime. He stepped directly onto the slippery, ghostly mess.

WHOOO-SLIDE!

His feet flew over his head. The bag of diamonds soared into the air, landing perfectly in a nearby trash can. The robber hit the pavement with a loud *THUD*, knocking himself out cold.

The shopkeeper and two police officers rushed over. "Incredible! He tripped on... nothing?" the officer said, looking at the clear sidewalk where the ghostly ice cream had already vanished.

Bucktooth stood over the fallen criminal, proudly holding his empty cone. "AHA! I HAVE DEPLOYED THE **TACTICAL DAIRY TRAP!** BEAVER JUSTICE PREVAILS!"

Mav looked at the robber, then at the Professor's smug face. "You literally just dropped your snack, Professor."

"I planned the trajectory with mathematical precision, Maverick! It was a calculated structural sabotage of his forward momentum!"

The Professor let out a manic, triumphant laugh, vanishing into a puff of blue smoke. Mav just stood there, finished his own ice cream, and decided that if "Beaver Justice" meant accidental victories through dessert-based clumsiness, he could live with that.